

music director at the opera house in Riga on the Baltic, but could not live on the income. In 1839, he and Minna fled to escape creditors—the stormy sea voyage inspired his ghost-ship opera *The Flying Dutchman*. Then came another two years of poverty and overspending in Paris, where he was again threatened with debtors' prison. Wagner's breakthrough work was *Rienzi*, a conventional grand opera in the style of established composers such as Vincenzo Bellini and Giacomo Meyerbeer. It was rejected in Paris but, with Meyerbeer's backing, accepted for performance at the Dresden opera house in Wagner's native Saxony. The success of this production in 1842, and of *The Flying Dutchman* in 1843, led to his appointment as director of music at Saxony's royal court. There he wrote *Tannhäuser*, performed in Dresden in 1845, and *Lohengrin*, completed in 1848. Drawing on Germanic myth, these mature works established Wagner's originality as an operatic composer.

Revolution and escape

Political upheaval prevented *Lohengrin* from being premiered in Dresden. In 1848, the German kingdoms, including Saxony, faced uprisings and demands for a unified German nation-state. Wagner sided with the revolutionaries, advocating a German national theater and embracing republicanism. In May 1849, after street fighting, the rebels in Dresden were suppressed. Known for his revolutionary sympathies, Wagner fled to Switzerland to escape arrest, becoming a political exile banned from all German states.